

Assignment 1

Introduction to Linguistics 2

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Question 1:

Synonymy:

Words with closely related meanings are said to be synonymous. Their meanings need not be completely same(absolute synonymy); they can differ depending upon the context.

Antonymy:

Words with opposite meanings are said to be antonymous. They can be:

- a. Binary (Non-Gradable)
- b. Polar(Gradable)

Hyponymy:

Words where the meaning of one is included in the meaning of the other, are said to be hyponyms.

English:

Semantic circularity in synonyms:

- 1. **Important:** of great **significance** or value.
Significant: sufficiently great or **important** to be worthy of attention; noteworthy.
- 2. **Complete:** **finish** making or doing.
Finish: bring (a task or activity) to an end; **complete**.

Semantic circularity in antonyms:

- 3. **Dead:** no longer **alive**.
Alive: (of a person, animal, or plant) living, not **dead**.

Semantic circularity in hyponyms:

4. **Vehicle:** a thing used for transporting people or goods, especially on land, such as a **car**, lorry, or cart.
Car: a four-wheeled road **vehicle** that is powered by an engine and is able to carry a small number of people.
(Car comes under the set of Vehicles)
5. **Vertebrate:** an animal of a large group distinguished by the possession of a backbone or spinal column, including mammals, **birds**, reptiles, amphibians, and fishes.
Bird: a warm-blooded egg-laying **vertebrate** animal distinguished by the possession of feathers, wings, a beak, and typically by being able to fly.
(Bird comes under the set of Vertebrates)

Hindi:

Semantic circularity in synonyms:

1. **आज़ादी:** स्वतंत्रता, स्वाधीनता। किसी दूसरे के अधीन न रहकर, अपनी इच्छा अनुसार जीने, कार्य करने और अभिव्यक्त करने की स्थिति। बंधन, **गुलामी**, या कैद से रिहाई का भाव।
स्वतंत्रता: गुलामी से मुक्ति, स्वाधीनता, **आज़ादी**।
2. **झूठ:** असत्य, मिथ्या बात, हकीकत के विपरीत कही गई कोई भी बात जो किसी को धोखा देने के इरादे से बोली या लिखी जाती है।
असत्य: झूठ, मिथ्या, गलत या अवास्तविक।

Semantic circularity in antonyms:

3. **बेईमान:** ईमानदार न होना, धोखेबाज।
ईमानदार: नेक नीयत वाला, सच्चा, और नैतिक रूप से सही व्यक्ति। **बेईमानी**, झूठ, चोरी या छल-कपट से दूर रहकर वफादार, निष्पक्ष और विश्वसनीय आचरण दर्शाने वाला।

Semantic circularity in hyponyms:

4. **फल:** पौधे का खाद्य, विकसित अंडाशय (जैसे आम, **सेब**), जो फूलों से उत्पन्न होता है और जिसमें बीज होते हैं
आम: एक लोकप्रिय रसीला **फल**, जिसे फलों का राजा कहा जाता है और जो भारत का राष्ट्रीय फल है।
5. **गुस्सा:** क्रोध, रोष, या नाराजगी । एक तीव्र नकारात्मक **भावना**, जो किसी व्यक्ति, वस्तु या परिस्थिति के प्रति असंतोष, हताशा, डर, या अपमान के कारण उत्पन्न होती है।
भावना: मन की स्थिति, संवेग, अनुभूति या विचार। किसी अनुभव, परिस्थिति या व्यक्ति के प्रति मन में पैदा होने वाली तीव्र प्रतिक्रिया जैसे- खुशी, दुख, प्यार, **गुस्सा**, जो मानसिक और शारीरिक रूप से महसूस की जाती है।

French:

Semantic circularity in synonyms:

1. **liberté:** La liberté en philosophie se définit généralement comme l'état de non-contrainte ou le pouvoir d'agir selon sa propre volonté, sans entrave
 extérieurelibération, **indépendance**, faculté, facilité

*(Freedom in philosophy is generally defined as the state of non-constraint or the power to act according to one's own will, without external hindrance.
 liberation, independence, faculty, ease)*

indépendance: En philosophie, l'indépendance désigne l'état d'un être, d'une pensée ou d'un système qui ne dépend que de lui-même, se caractérisant par une absence de soumission à des contraintes extérieures, des règles imposées ou une tutelle spirituelle.
Liberté, libération, indépendance, faculté, facilité

*(In philosophy, independence designates the state of a being, a thought, or a system that depends only on itself, characterized by an absence of submission to external constraints, imposed rules, or spiritual tutelage.
 freedom, liberation, independence, faculty, ease)*

2. **erreur:** faute, méprise l'erreur est définie comme un acte de l'esprit tenant pour vrai ce qui est faux, ou inversement, résultant souvent d'un jugement précipité (Descartes) ou d'un manque de connaissance.

(Mistake, fault, misunderstanding. Error is defined as an act of the mind that takes what is false to be true, or vice versa, often resulting from a hasty judgment (Descartes) or from a lack of knowledge.)

faute: défaut, erreur, tort, démerite.

(Defect, error, wrong, fault, demerit)

3. **travail:** œuvre, profession, ouvrage, **emploi**, boulot.

(work, creation, profession, piece of work, employment, job)

emploi: l'emploi ou le **travail** est défini comme une action consciente, volontaire et transformatrice, par laquelle l'être humain façonne son environnement pour satisfaire ses besoins, s'objectivant ainsi dans le monde.

(Employment or work is defined as a conscious, voluntary, and transformative action through which the human being shapes their environment to satisfy their needs, thereby objectifying themselves in the world.)

Semantic circularity in antonyms:

4. **bien:** le bien désigne ce qui est jugé moralement correct, souhaitable, ou conforme à un idéal, s'opposant au **mal**.

(The good designates what is judged morally correct, desirable, or in accordance with an ideal, and is opposed to Evil)

mal: le mal désigne tout ce qui est contraire au **bien**, à la vertu ou à l'ordre, se manifestant principalement comme une souffrance subie ou une action nuisible intentionnelle.

(Evil designates everything that is contrary to the good, to virtue, or to order, manifesting primarily as suffered pain or as an intentional harmful action)

5. **vrai:** le vrai se définit classiquement comme l'adéquation ou la conformité entre un jugement (la pensée, le discours) et le réel (la réalité objective ou l'idée). Il s'oppose au **faux**, à l'illusion ou à l'opinion, et peut se caractériser par la cohérence logique, l'évidence, ou la correspondance vérifiable.

(The true is classically defined as the adequation or conformity between a judgment (thought or discourse) and the real (objective reality or the idea). It is opposed to the false, illusion, or opinion, and may be characterized by logical coherence, evidence, or verifiable correspondence)

faux: le **faux** est défini comme le contraire du vrai, désignant ce qui n'est pas conforme à la réalité, à la logique ou à la vérité.

(The false is defined as the opposite of the true, designating that which does not conform to reality, logic, or truth)

Question 2:

How has the notion of circularity (in general, not specifically semantic) been used to define the relationship between language and thought, i.e., how do language and thought influence each other?

The relationship between language and thought is circular in nature.

Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis:

Thought of by Edward Sapir, who stated “Language of the society predisposed certain choices of interpretation about how we view the world”, and Benjamin Lee Whorf, “We dissect nature along the lines laid down by our native languages.”;

It essentially refers to how the languages we communicate in are themselves affected by social factors, which in turn changes the way we perceive and cognize the world around us.

Eg.

Language: Telugu

Social factor: Caste difference

Type of water	Non-Brahmin	Brahmin
Drinking water	ṭanni	ṭirtṭō
Water(general)	ṭanni	jalō
Non-potable water	ṭanni	ṭanni

An argument can be made that the reason the Brahmins have more Sanskritised words for drinking water and water in general is due to:

1. Historically, having better access to education (primarily in Sanskrit)
2. A way to add spirituality and formality to rituals by using non-standard words (eg. Ganga-jal instead of Ganga-paani)

Historically, non-Brahmins had limited access to resources in comparison with the Brahmins, especially when it came to water (primarily drinking water).

Thus, water in general is referred to by a single word due to the lack of any need to refer to different types of water.

If you have very limited amounts of one resource, you won't go into details about which type is used for what purpose.

Also, due to the prevalence of untouchability, the non-Brahmin word for water 'ṭānni', is pejoratively used by the Brahmins for non-potable water.

Impact of Neologisms on Cognition:

This circular relationship is reflected in how neologisms arise and change:

1. Language lacks the word for a concept, idea or thought:
Eg.
 - a. No word used to refer to the adverse environmental impact of growing carbon emissions.
 - b. No word used to refer to the feeling of helplessness, unfulfillment and anxiety felt by American housewives in the 1960s (Betty Frieden's 'The Feminine Mystique' ("The Problem That Has No Name"))
2. Word added to fulfill that need in language:
Eg.
 - a. Climate Change, Global Warming, Carbon Footprint.
 - b. Suburban Neurosis, Housewife Syndrome, Domestic Containment Ideology.
3. Usage of that word makes it easier to conceptualize the idea it represents.
Later, the connotations of these words rework the way we actually perceive the idea in question.
Eg.
 - a. Milder words like 'Change' and 'Warming' make the climate crisis seem less urgent.

It shifts the focus from the very real impact of climate change on human health, food security, water availability, natural disasters, loss of bio-diversity, etc. and simply concentrates on rising sea levels and increasing global temperatures.

Again, all this makes the problem seem more trivial in comparison.

‘Carbon Footprint’, coined by British Petroleum, makes the problem seem more individual specific, making one feel that it can only be resolved if the average person reduces, recycles and reuses; absolving British Petroleum of the destructive impacts of **THEIR** actions on the environment.

- b. ‘Syndrome’ and ‘Neurosis’ have medical connotations, suggesting clinical, rather than social causes for dissatisfaction. Though this helped in raising mental health awareness, especially regarding anxiety and depression, it removed the social factors causing ‘The Problem That Has No Name’ (rigid patriarchal norms, gender role expectations, devaluation of unpaid domestic labor, societal pressure, isolation, lack of recognition etc.) from discourse.

‘Ideology’ linked this problem from one’s personal life to a matter of national security. Due to the Cold War, this ‘Ideology’ positioned the nuclear family as a secure, private, and consumer-oriented ‘bastion of safety’ against Communism

Modern Whorfism:

Modern Whorfism takes a weaker approach towards the Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis. It states that:

1. One’s pattern of thinking can be **INFLUENCED**, not **DETERMINED** by language.

That is, language is used to simply impose a structure on our reality (not alter the way we perceive it), and this socially accepted structure helps communicate ideas, biases and schools of thought, more effectively.

2. Language influences the way we see the world and is in- turn influenced by it.

Eg. The way neologisms are coined, and then alter their meaning as they’re used in different contexts.

Thus, **Thought**: cognition, biases, cultural context, relation between speaker and listener etc.; affects the way a speaker uses **Language** and how they communicate with the listener, whereas **Language** can be used to alter patterns of **Thinking** and Cognition: push ideas to the forefront of discourse, alter patterns of thinking, impact cultural consciousness, challenge biases, enforce biases etc.

Hence, there’s circularity when it comes to the relationship between language and thought.

